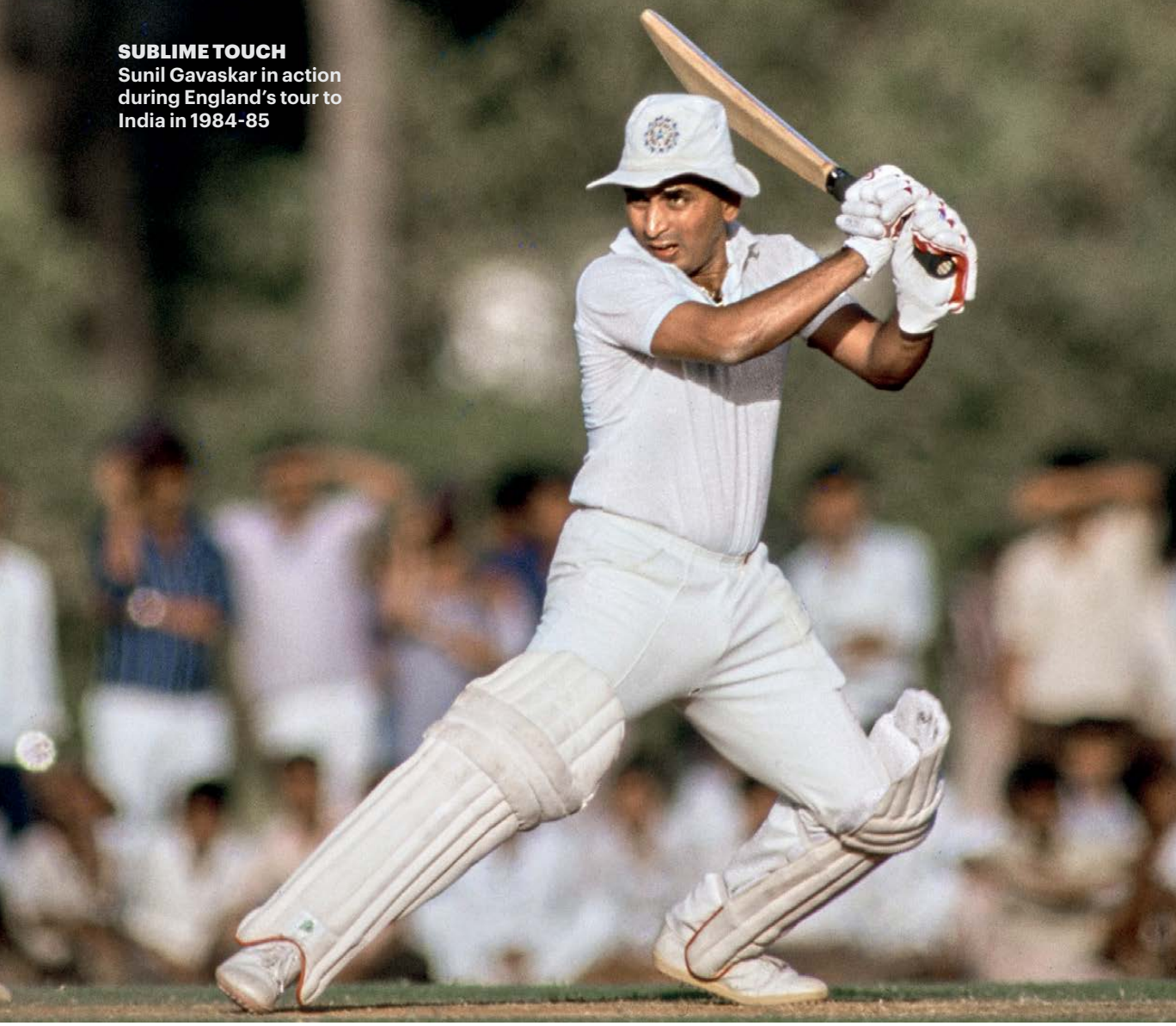


SUBLIME TOUCH
Sunil Gavaskar in action during England's tour to India in 1984-85

GETTY IMAGES

After the match, his baby brown eyes were brimming with tears. That night he couldn't sleep and kept replaying his innings in his mind, agonising over the shot that finally got him caught. For Gavaskar, Sachin's ability to introspect over his game, admit mistakes and correct them is a sign of greatness. Says he: "There are no masters in this game, only students. And Sachin is the rare cricketer who is learning all the time. He is growing at a phenomenal rate and the sky is the limit for him."

–Raj Chengappa

"Once you get to that 10,000 it is absolutely magical because it had not been done before... almost like climbing Mt Everest for the first time"

— SUNIL GAVASKAR

in Bangalore. Those who prefer vintage champagne would pick that one. Picking a Gavaskar moment is difficult—there were plenty of a world-historic nature. Take, for unusual savagery, his 121 to equal Don Bradman's record of 29 Test centuries. This was the 'Revenge Series' for the Windies, after their 1983 World Cup shock. The pacers from hell, Malcolm Marshall and Michael Holding, were in murderous mood. But Sunny hooked and hooked—50 in 37 balls, 100 in 94 balls. No helmet.

As his runs surged in recurrent, ocean-sized purple patches, some said he was too record-minded. Others carped about the runs he *didn't* score. Neither gets his essence, his presence at the crease. Wouldn't that be the best way to map him? As a body moving through space? If batsmanship were poetry, Gavaskar would be haiku. A tiny amount of air displaced—precise geometry, economy of motion. Head utterly still under that ten-gallon hat or skull cap. Torso, limbs in preternatural poise as he shifted his upright willow a wee micrometre inside of a swinging cherry, and the voice on the radio would say: "*Perfectly judged, again.*" Yes, his best may indeed have been the runs he didn't score. ■